Studying with GenAI: Student Views on the Opportunities and Risks of GenAI in Higher Education

Abstract

The emergence of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) technology and the increasing sophistication of such tools have raised concerns about their impact on teaching, learning, and assessment in higher education. To gain an understanding of how students are using GenAI tools for studying and assessments, and to explore their perceptions of its benefits and challenges in higher education, this qualitative study examined the views of Psychology students from two UK universities. Six focus groups (N = 28), consisting of postgraduate psychology students and a few UG students were conducted using semi-structured interview questions to explore their experiences and attitudes toward the use of GenAI during their studies. Students reported using GenAI to summarise content, clarify complex ideas, and ease the writing process. While they recognised its value, especially for accessibility and time management, they also expressed concerns about plagiarism, reduced critical thinking, and unclear boundaries of ethical use. Many felt anxious about academic integrity due to inconsistent guidance. Notably, some students viewed AI use as ethically problematic, particularly in group work. The findings underscore the urgent need for clearer institutional policies and targeted training to promote ethical, effective engagement with GenAI in academic contexts.